



OFF-SIDE

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IF SPORT CAN'T STAND UP TO POWER, IT STANDS FOR NOTHING

Donald Trump's threat to **"take away"** World Cup games in Boston exposes how fragile sport's independence really is — and how easily power bends its ideals.

"I love the people of Boston, and I know the games are sold out. But your mayor is not good," Donald Trump said recently. "We could take them away. We have the right to do that with FIFA. I could call Gianni, the head of FIFA, and say, 'Let's move it to another location,' and he would do it, very easily."

The threat continued as he hinted that he might also look at the Los Angeles Olympics.

This was a direct assertion that political power can override the supposed independence of international sport. When a U.S. president threatens to "take away" global events as if they were personal assets, it exposes the fragility of sport's autonomy and sets a dangerous precedent.

FIFA, the IOC, and every other sporting body thrive on the myth of neutrality. In reality, they depend on governments for host-city guarantees, visas, security, and public money.

FIFA's clarification: "Safety and security are the top priorities at all FIFA events worldwide. Safety and security are obviously the governments' responsibility, and they decide what is in the best interest of public safety. We hope every one of our 16 host cities will be ready to successfully host and fulfil all necessary requirements," read nowhere close to an assertion of autonomy and came across as a carefully worded statement meant to placate power.

The episode mirrors a wider trend. At the recent Sharm El-Sheikh summit, Pakistan's Prime Minister went out of his way to praise Trump, unprompted and unprovoked. Across the world, leaders and institutions alike seem eager to appease power rather than test it.

Sport has always been political, sometimes subtly, sometimes unmistakably. The 1936 Berlin Olympics served as a propaganda event for Nazi Germany, while the 1980 Moscow and 1984 Los Angeles Games were caught up in boycott and counter-boycott by the Western and Eastern blocs at the height of the Cold War. Today, India and Pakistan no longer play in each other's countries. At the recent Asia Cup T20 tournament and the ongoing Women's ODI World Cup, players didn't shake hands following the horrific Pahalgam attack and India's retaliation. Every gesture, or the absence of one, is interpreted as a statement of national intent.

Handshakes are not mandatory in sport. Elina Svitolina and Marta Kostyuk of Ukraine refuse to shake hands with Russian or Belarusian opponents in tennis, but Olga Kharlan, a Ukrainian fencer and six-time Olympic medallist, was disqualified from the 2023 World Fencing Championships for declining to shake hands with her Russian counterpart.

And yet, there are still glimpses of what sport can be. **Before their match at the Sultan Johor Cup, junior hockey players of India and Pakistan exchanged high-fives, a reminder that sport's unifying spirit survives best when left to athletes, not administrators.**

If FIFA, the IOC, or any other global body has a duty now, it is to protect the game from political interference. For journalists, fans, and citizens alike, the task is vigilance. Sport's beauty lies in its autonomy, its ability to let rivals coexist without rancour. We should not yield that field to agendas that serve narrow ends, when sport's true purpose is the shared human pursuit of excellence.